The Renaissance Leader: Chandni Kapadia's Extraordinary Journey Across Industries

From revolutionising luxury retail to transforming higher education, this dynamic leader is redefining success across multiple domains.

In an era where specialisation is often the norm, Chandni Kapadia stands as a compelling counterexample—a renaissance professional whose extraordinary career traverses the seemingly disparate worlds of fashion, corporate leadership, law, and academic administration. Her journey represents a masterclass in versatile leadership that has left an indelible mark on each sector she touches.

Kapadia's professional journey began at New York's prestigious Fashion Institute of Technology, where she developed a sophisticated understanding of design aesthetics and brand positioning. This creative foundation, later augmented by an MBA from the London School of Economics, created a rare confluence of artistic sensibility and business acumen that would become her signature strength.

"Her ability to see both the creative vision and commercial potential simultaneously is what makes her exceptional," notes a former colleague from her fashion industry days. This distinctive perspective proved invaluable when she spearheaded Starbucks' entry into the Indian market—a strategic move requiring delicate cultural translation of a global brand into a tea-drinking nation's landscape.

As Country Head and later Asia-Pacific leader for international fashion powerhouses including Accessorize and Calvin Klein, Kapadia demonstrated remarkable dexterity in managing cross-cultural teams while driving aggressive market expansion. Her leadership philosophy centres on inclusive excellence: "Working with diverse teams fosters a spirit of innovation that transcends borders," she explains, a principle that has guided her management approach across continents.

Perhaps most remarkably, Kapadia pursued legal education in parallel to her demanding executive roles, ultimately earning eleven gold medals for her academic excellence. This legal expertise has enhanced her capacity to navigate complex regulatory environments and make strategically sound decisions that protect organisational interests while promoting ethical business practices.

For the past decade, Kapadia has channelled her multidimensional expertise into transforming GLS University into a globally recognised centre for business education. Under her stewardship, the institution has established prestigious international collaborations with Harvard and Newcastle University, fundamentally recalibrating the educational experience for students preparing to enter an increasingly complex global marketplace.

"What distinguishes Chandni's approach to education is her insistence on real-world relevance," explains a faculty member. "She bridges the gap between theoretical knowledge and practical application in ways that genuinely prepare students for leadership roles."

Kapadia's contributions have earned her significant recognition, including being honoured as Asia's Most Trusted Leader at London's House of Lords and receiving the Black Swan Award for Women Empowerment. As a TEDx speaker, she shares insights drawn from her multifaceted career, inspiring professionals to embrace bold innovation and calculated risk-taking.

Despite her demanding professional commitments, Kapadia remains dedicated to animal welfare advocacy.



Chandni Kapadia
Executive Director, GLS University

"Protecting vulnerable creatures reflects our humanity at its core," she asserts, working actively with organisations promoting ethical animal treatment and environmental sustainability.

Chandni Kapadia's remarkable journey demonstrates that true leadership transcends industry boundaries. By seamlessly integrating creative vision, business strategy, legal expertise, and compassionate advocacy, she continues to set new standards of excellence while inspiring the next generation of global leaders to pursue impact beyond conventional limitations.